

TRUE GRIT
CM Pushkar Dhami and Union minister V.K. Singh greeting a rescued worker, Nov. 28

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UTTARAKHAND TUNNEL COLLAPSE

THE GREAT INDIAN RESCUE

By Avishek G. Dastidar

Sixteen days too late, but Diwali finally came for the 41 labourers who got trapped after a portion of the under-construction Silkyara-Barkot tunnel collapsed in Uttarakhand on November 12. It took over 400 hours of sheer resolve as rescue workers from multiple agencies, under the PMO's constant vigil, provided logistics to drill through the 60-metre-thick rubble, while on the other side, the trapped men held on to hope and sanity.

After a string of setbacks, it was by the afternoon of November 28 that rescue looked imminent as 'rat-hole' miners started burrowing through the remaining two metres of the debris using hand-held tools. Around 8 in the evening, the disaster response personnel eventually wheeled out all the trapped workers in quick succession (see *How They Did It*).

"We were doing morning walks in the two-km stretch inside. We also did yoga some days. We helped each other; kept our morale high...," a labourer told Prime Minister Narendra Modi who, at night, spoke to them over the phone. The PM told them he was happy to learn that "all of you are fine, health-wise".

As the dust settles, a question looms large—whether big-ticket infrastructure projects like the Char Dham highways are safe for the fragile Himalayas? The government will do a technical audit of the tunnel to see what went wrong, even as the NHAI has instituted a third-party audit of all its tunnels.